

Starting as a new Project or Program Manager?

How to make an impact in your FIRST 90 DAYS

Your first 90 days as a Project or Program Manager set the tone for everything that follows. These 10 moves will help you build trust, surface what matters, and make an early impact without overstepping before you have the full picture.

■ People and relationships

■ Process and systems

#1

Meet every stakeholder fast.

Schedule 1:1s with sponsors, stakeholders, and team leads in week one. Ask what success looks like to them. Their definition matters more than the charter right now.

#2

Shadow your team in their natural habitat.

Sit in on standups, retros, and syncs without an agenda. Watch how the team actually works, not how the process doc says they should.

#3

Audit the project history.

Read every doc, deck, and decision log you can find. Know what was tried, what failed, and why. Walking in with context earns trust faster than any introduction.

#4

Map every dependency ruthlessly.

Draw out the dependency web: teams, systems, timelines. Unspoken dependencies are how projects die quietly. Surface them early.

#5

Learn what 'done' actually means.

Deeply understand the 3-4 outcomes your project is actually being measured against. Scope documents lie. The metrics your sponsor watches don't.

#6

Get close to your executive sponsor.

Learn how they prefer updates: email, Slack, verbal? Weekly or as-needed? How much detail? Matching their rhythm makes you indispensable, not just present.

#7

Find the informal influencers.

Every program has people without PM titles who quietly unblock everything. Identify them. Build rapport early. They are your most valuable early allies.

#8

Build your single source of truth.

Create one living document: status, risks, decisions, open questions, and the schedule. If it's not in there, it doesn't exist. This becomes the project's memory.

#9

No big process changes yet.

Improving communication and documenting gaps is fine. But don't overhaul workflows, tools, or ceremonies for at least 90 days. Earn the right to change things first.

#10

Deliver one early, visible win.

Find something stuck, ambiguous, or overdue and resolve it cleanly. A quick, concrete win signals that you're an unblocking force, not just a meeting organizer.

Curated by [Ashaki Sorrell](#) | For new Project & Program Managers ready to make their mark